AN OPEN CALL FOR BUILDERS AND FUNDERS — 2026

The next internet will not be won with better technology.

The engineering is mostly done. The protocols exist. The cryptography works. What doesn't exist yet is a system where contributing to the commons is the individually rational move — not just the morally right one. That is the problem worth solving. And it is worth a great deal.

THE PROBLEM

The current internet was designed for resilience and captured by economics. Every major decentralized network of the last two decades — peer-to-peer file sharing, early crypto, federated social — either died, got re-centralized, or got gamed into uselessness. Not because the technology failed. Because the incentives failed.

Five companies now control the infrastructure, identity, and attention of half the world. That is not an accident of engineering. It is the outcome of a coordination problem that nobody has solved at scale.

> The tragedy of the commons isn't inevitable. Elinor Ostrom proved it. Communities govern shared resources sustainably when the rules are designed correctly. The question is whether those rules can be encoded into a global network — and what it would take to find out.

THE OPPORTUNITY

Every device on earth is idle most of the time. Collectively, consumer hardware represents more compute, storage, and bandwidth than all the hyperscalers combined — stranded, unused, generating nothing for its owners. A network that routes value back to contributors doesn't just fix a philosophical problem. It creates an entirely new economic layer.

COMPUTE

Distributed inference

AI that runs across idle devices. No single company owns the model or captures the margin.

BANDWIDTH

Mesh routing credits

Devices earn for forwarding packets. Coverage becomes a function of population, not ISP economics.

STORAGE

Content-addressed permanence

Data that survives as long as anyone cares enough to seed it. No single point of failure.

IDENTITY

Portable reputation

Trust you earned travels with you. No platform can hold your relationships hostage.

WHAT WE ARE LOOKING FOR

This is not a whitepaper. It is a call for people willing to run experiments. The theory is strong. The empirical record from Ostrom, Axelrod, and mechanism design is clear about what conditions make cooperation stable. What doesn't yet exist is a working implementation at internet scale — and the only way to find it is to build and measure.

The specific unsolved questions are tractable:

— How do you verify that a node contributed real bandwidth, not simulated bandwidth?

— What credit mechanism resists Sybil attacks without requiring centralized identity?

— Can quadratic funding sustain open infrastructure the way it has sustained open source?

— What is the minimum viable governance structure for a commons that scales past Dunbar's number?

THE ASK

01

Funding to experiment

Small grants to run real-world incentive experiments — meshes, compute markets, reputation systems — and measure what actually holds.

02

Infrastructure to test on

Access to devices, networks, and users willing to participate in live trials. Theory without measurement is just philosophy.

03

Collaborators who build

Engineers, mechanism designers, and economists who want to work on the coordination layer — not another application on top of it.

WHY NOW

The consolidation of internet infrastructure is not slowing — it is accelerating, and AI is compressing the timeline. Within a decade, a small number of entities will control not just distribution and identity but inference itself. The window to build an alternative coordination layer at the protocol level is open, but it is not open indefinitely.

The technology needed to attempt this has existed for years. What hasn't existed is a focused effort to solve the game theory first and treat the engineering as a known cost. That reordering of priorities is what this initiative represents.

The internet wasn't built by the people who captured it. It was built by people who thought they were building infrastructure. We are looking for that kind of builder — one who is more interested in getting the foundation right than in owning what gets built on top of it.

If you are funding experiments at the infrastructure layer, building in this space, or have relevant research — we want to talk.

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